

Maria Silva

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LLB and LLM graduate with hands-on experience in client-facing legal advice, case file management, procedural drafting and document handling across family, housing, employment and disputes matters. Currently advising clients at Citizens Advice East Berkshire on family, welfare and housing issues, managing matters from instruction to submission. Previous placement at BCLP developed skills in hearing bundle preparation, deadline tracking, court filing and working under pressure on complex, document-heavy matters. Strong written communication, attention to detail and experience dealing sensitively with vulnerable clients.

EDUCATION

Comparative and International Dispute Resolution LLM — Merit Sept 2024 – Oct 2025

Queen Mary University of London

- Modules in international arbitration, dispute resolution procedure, evidence analysis and legal research
- Transnational Law and Governance Applied module (data privacy and democracy) — 75%
- Dissertation on data protection and GDPR development across jurisdictions

Law LLB — 2:1 Sept 2020 – June 2024

University College London

- Modules included Alternative Dispute Resolution, Advanced Contract Law, Commercial Law and Company Law

International Foundation Programme in Law and International Relations Sept 2019 – June 2020

King's College London

- Awarded the Leaders of Tomorrow prize (top 20 of 200-student cohort; partial funding toward undergraduate degree)

EXPERIENCE

Citizens Advice East Berkshire · Maidenhead July 2026 – Present

Legal Adviser

- Advises clients on family, housing, welfare benefits, employment, debt and consumer matters; takes detailed factual statements, establishes chronologies and identifies relevant legal and evidential issues
- Manages matters from initial instruction through to submission: drafts correspondence, prepares applications and document schedules, maintains confidential case records and meets deadlines
- Assesses eligibility for Universal Credit, Housing Benefit and related support against statutory criteria; identifies evidential gaps and researches complex points
- Translates complex procedural rules into clear, practical guidance for vulnerable and distressed clients

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London Aug 2023 – Feb 2024

Legal Placement Student — International Arbitration

- Supported a complex investment arbitration: reviewed and organised evidence for procedural submissions and the Claimant's memorial; amended sections of the memorial and drafted procedural orders and procedural histories
- Became the only junior supporting the team shortly before a significant filing deadline: coordinated documents, tracked outstanding actions and helped ensure on-time submission
- Maintained structured electronic case files and monitored procedural deadlines; liaised with the client on required documents and coordinated external translations
- Received feedback from a partner and associate that performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London Feb 2024 – Aug 2024

Legal Placement Student — Real Estate Disputes

- Prepared electronic hearing bundles, assisted with skeleton arguments and supported court filing and hearing arrangements
- Conducted legal and factual research on rights of light, easements, leasehold issues and landlord and tenant disputes
- Maintained matter records via iManage; managed large volumes of confidential documents across several matters with competing deadlines
- Assisted with matter opening and closure, deadline tracking and cost comparisons

Q-Legal · London**Oct 2024 – Jan 2025****Legal Adviser**

- Managed a data-privacy matter from client instruction through to formal written advice letter under a qualified solicitor's supervision
- Researched UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 obligations; identified compliance risks and recommended practical mitigations
- Translated complex statutory requirements into clear, commercially focused advice; coordinated with the client and supervising solicitor to meet the agreed deadline

Adobe · London**June 2022 – Aug 2022****Legal Intern**

- Reviewed and amended software licensing agreements; identified contractual risks and assessed alignment with internal legal and compliance requirements
- Reviewed confidentiality and data-processing provisions; researched UK GDPR, EU GDPR and cross-border data transfer requirements
- Liaised with sales, legal and international business teams to resolve contractual queries; communicated amendments to stakeholders
- Prepared and delivered an internal presentation on breach-of-contract risks and mitigation measures

SKILLS

Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (basic)

Technical skills: Legal and commercial research; documentary analysis; concise report and correspondence writing; Microsoft Word, Excel and PowerPoint; iManage; legal research databases; electronic court filing portals; electronic bundling; case management and time-recording systems

Case and evidence management: Case file organisation and maintenance; evidence review; hearing bundle preparation; procedural drafting; deadline tracking across multiple concurrent matters; client-facing advice and correspondence